

It was the long-distance raid behind enemy lines where a cavalry unit came into its own. In the wide open spaces of the West, a body of horsemen could move undetected, striking suddenly to destroy railroad or telegraph links, plunder depots, and overrun isolated garrisons. The Confederates set the example. In 1862, General Nathan Bedford Forrest and General John Morgan led raids badly disrupting Union operations in the Western Theater. In effect fighting as guerrilla forces, the South's cavalry roamed across hundreds of miles in the Union rear, tying down troops ten times their number. Their impact was such that, during General William T. Sherman's advance on Atlanta in 1864, almost 100,000 Union troops were engaged in the defense of communications and pursuit of enemy marauders. But the Union responded. General Benjamin Grierson's 400-mile (640-km) sweep through Confederate-held territory from Tennessee to Louisiana in 1863 played a major part in Grant's Vicksburg Campaign.

Northern advantage

In the end, the Union's superior resources would give it the advantage. From 1864, General Philip Sheridan's cavalry corps was a dominant force in the Eastern Theater. His pursuit of Lee's army in the final stage of the war was an example of cavalry used in a traditional role to great effect. By the war's end, Union cavalry outnumbered Confederate horsemen by two to one. Short of decent mounts and fodder, the Confederate cavalry was reduced to a sorry condition, some of its units little better than bandits engaged in a struggle for survival.